

COMPLETE UNIT

KS3: Causes of the Great War



COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: How did decades of imperial rivalry and fear culminate in thirty days of madness?

Contents

Lesson 1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?

Lesson 2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

Lesson 3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

Lesson 4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

Lesson 5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

Lesson 6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

THE GERMAN REICH 1871-1918

The map illustrates the territorial composition of the German Reich during the Imperial era. It shows the following provinces and territories:

- Provinz Schleswig-Holstein**
- Provinz Hannover**
- Provinz Westfalen**
- Provinz Sachsen**
- Provinz Brandenburg**
- Provinz Pommern**
- Provinz Ostpreußen**
- Provinz Westpreußen**
- Provinz Posens**
- Provinz Schlesien**
- Provinz Hessen-Nassau**
- Provinz Hessen**
- Provinz Baden**
- Provinz Württemberg**
- Provinz Bayern**
- Provinz Rheinland**
- Provinz Elsass-Lothringen**
- Provinz Kärnten**
- Provinz Tirol**
- Provinz Salzburg**
- Provinz Steiermark**
- Provinz Kroatien**
- Provinz Bosnien und Herzegowina**
- Provinz Serbien**
- Provinz Montenegro**
- Provinz Albanien**
- Provinz Mazedonien**
- Provinz Bulgarien**
- Provinz Rumänien**
- Provinz Griechenland**
- Provinz Türkei**
- Provinz Persien**
- Provinz Indien**
- Provinz China**
- Provinz Japan**
- Provinz Korea**
- Provinz Philippinen**
- Provinz Ostasien**
- Provinz Südsee**
- Provinz Australien**
- Provinz Neuseeland**
- Provinz Südamerika**
- Provinz Nordamerika**
- Provinz Afrika**
- Provinz Asien**
- Provinz Europa**
- Provinz Ozeanien**
- Provinz Antarktika**

Legend:

- FHZ = Fürstentum Hohenzollern (zu Preußen)
- LD = Fürstentum Lippe
- OLD = zu Großherzogtum Oldenburg
- RÄL = Fürstentum Reuß ältere Linie
- RJL = Fürstentum Reuß jüngere Linie
- SA = Herzogtum Sachsen-Altenburg
- SCG = Herzogtum Sachsen-Coburg und Gotha
- SL = Fürstentum Schaumburg-Lippe
- SMG = Herzogtum Sachsen-Meiningen
- SR = Fürstentum Schwarzburg-Rudolstadt
- SWE = Großherzogtum Sachsen-Weimar-Eisenach
- W = Fürstentum Waldeck und Pyrmont (Landesteil Pyrmont)



L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand how Prussia used economic dominance (the Zollverein) and military reform to eclipse Austria.
- ☐ Analyze how Bismarck orchestrated three short, decisive wars to achieve unification.
- ☐ Evaluate the geopolitical consequences of the proclamation at Versailles and the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle *ONE* term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Realpolitik | Blood and Iron | Zollverein | Alsace-Lorraine | Balance of Power

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Source S1 : Map A: The German Empire in Central Europe (1871)



Geopolitical map showing the unification of thirty-nine sovereign German states into the German Empire under Prussian leadership in 1871.

Source S2 : Map B: Modern European Boundaries vs 1871 Frontiers



Comparative cartography overlaying 1871 German imperial boundaries onto modern sovereign European borders.

[1.1] For centuries following the 1648 Peace of Westphalia, Central Europe remained a politically fragmented patchwork of hundreds of small, independent German-speaking principalities, duchies, and bishoprics. In 1815, the Congress of Vienna consolidated these territories into a loose confederation of thirty-nine sovereign states, within which two Great Powers fiercely competed for continental pre-eminence: the Catholic Austrian Empire and the Protestant military Kingdom of Prussia. While Austria remained an agrarian, multi-ethnic empire preoccupied with holding together its restive nationalities, Prussia underwent an explosive industrial transformation fueled by the rich coal and iron deposits of the Ruhr Valley and Silesia.

[1.2] In 1834, Prussia secured a decisive geopolitical masterstroke by establishing the *Zollverein* (Customs Union). By dismantling internal tariffs between German states while erecting protective customs walls against foreign imports, the *Zollverein* bound the economies of northern and central Germany inexorably to Berlin. Austria, crippled by its protectionist economic model, was deliberately excluded. Through the rapid construction of an integrated railway network, Prussia proved that industrial efficiency, economic prosperity, and modernized communication belonged to Berlin, establishing the economic foundation for political unification.

[2.1] In 1862, King Wilhelm I of Prussia appointed a ruthless, arch-conservative Junker nobleman named **Otto von Bismarck** as Minister President. Bismarck possessed an unyielding contempt for parliamentary liberalism and democratic debate. In his maiden address to the Prussian budget committee, he issued a stark manifesto that would define the era: *"The great questions of the day will not be decided by speeches and resolutions of majorities... but by **blood and iron**."* By "blood," Bismarck meant the sacrifice of conscripted soldiers; by "iron," he meant the devastating technological superiority of Prussian Krupp steel artillery, breech-loading Dreyse needle-guns, and precise military railway timetables.

[2.2] Bismarck orchestrated three short, ruthlessly calculated diplomatic and military campaigns. In 1864, Prussia allied with Austria to defeat Denmark, securing Schleswig-Holstein. In 1866, Bismarck turned upon Austria in the Seven Weeks' War; the modernized Prussian army under General Helmuth von Moltke annihilated Austrian forces at Königgrätz, expelling Austria permanently from German affairs and forming the North German Confederation. Finally, to unite the hesitant, Catholic southern German kingdoms (Bavaria, Württemberg, and Baden), Bismarck provoked France into declaring war in 1870. The Franco-Prussian War saw Prussian forces crush the French army at Sedan, capture Emperor Napoleon III, and advance to besiege Paris.

[3.1] On 18 January 1871, inside the sacred heart of French monarchical grandeur—the **Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles**—Bismarck staged the supreme coronation. Amidst a sea of Prussian helmets and military banners, King Wilhelm I was proclaimed the first German Emperor (Kaiser). The location was a calculated act of psychological subjugation: German princes cheered the birth of the Kaiserreich while

German artillery shells were actively bombarding Paris just twelve miles away. Under the 1871 Treaty of Frankfurt, the defeated French Republic was forced to pay a punitive indemnity of five billion gold francs and surrender the vital industrial provinces of Alsace and northern Lorraine.

[3.2] Forensic cartographic analysis (Source A) reveals the monumental scale of the new Empire. Spanning over 540,000 square kilometers with 41 million citizens, the German Empire instantly formed the demographic and industrial colossus of continental Europe. Yet comparative modern cartography (Source B) highlights Germany's profound geographic vulnerability: positioned squarely in the center of Europe with few natural frontiers, Germany was permanently vulnerable to simultaneous assault from the west (France) and the east (Russia).

[4.1] Historians remain sharply divided over Bismarck's ultimate legacy. Traditional German historiography praised Bismarck as a genius of *Realpolitik*—a visionary statesman who masterminded a predetermined master plan for national unity. Conversely, revisionist historians such as A.J.P. Taylor demonstrate that Bismarck was primarily an opportunistic political gambler who reacted pragmatically to crises, using warfare to preserve Prussian aristocratic power against the rising tide of working-class socialism and liberal democracy.

[4.2] Whatever his personal motives, the consequences of 1871 were revolutionary. British statesman Benjamin Disraeli told Parliament that the German unification was a greater political event than the French Revolution: "*The balance of power has been entirely destroyed.*" By annexing Alsace-Lorraine and humiliating France at Versailles, Bismarck created an irreconcilable enemy on Germany's western border. For the next twenty years, Bismarck would devote his diplomatic career to an intricate web of alliances designed to keep France isolated, terrified that the newly united Germany would one day be crushed in a catastrophic two-front war.

Q1. Explain how Otto von Bismarck used "blood and iron" and diplomatic calculation to forge the German Empire in 1871.

L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain how the Hohenzollern crisis and the Ems Telegram provoked France into war in 1870.
- ☐ Analyze the military catastrophe of Sedan and the brutal Siege of Paris.
- ☐ Evaluate how "la revanche" and Bettannier's "La Tache Noire" institutionalized anti-German sentiment in France.

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

La Revanche | Ems Telegram | Treaty of Frankfurt | Sedan | Siege of Paris

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

Source S1 : Albert Bettannier: "La Tache Noire" (The Black Spot, 1887)



Source

Contemporary French painting depicting a classroom where the lost provinces of Alsace and Lorraine are shaded in mourning black on the national map.

Source S2 : Alsace-Lorraine & The Fortified German Glacis (1871)



Military annexation map showing the 14,000 square kilometers of French territory ceded to Germany under the Treaty of Frankfurt.

[1.1] In the late 1860s, Emperor Napoleon III of France watched with growing anxiety as Prussia eclipsed Austrian influence and unified northern Germany. When Queen Isabella II of Spain was deposed in 1868, the vacant Spanish crown was offered to Prince Leopold of Hohenzollern-Sigmaringen, a distant cousin of the Prussian King. The prospect of a Hohenzollern monarch reigning on both the Rhine and the Pyrenees provoked hysterical outrage in Paris, where French politicians decried the encirclement of

France. Under intense diplomatic pressure from Paris, Leopold prudently withdrew his candidacy, achieving a bloodless diplomatic triumph for France.

[1.2] However, the ambitious French foreign minister overplayed his hand by demanding a personal guarantee from King Wilhelm I of Prussia at the spa town of Bad Ems that a Hohenzollern would never again seek the Spanish throne. King Wilhelm politely refused and sent a factual telegraphic dispatch of the encounter to Chancellor Bismarck in Berlin. Bismarck recognized a golden historic opportunity: he condensed and edited the telegram so that the Prussian King and French ambassador appeared to have mutually insulted each other, then leaked the **Ems Telegram** to the press on Bastille Day. French national pride erupted in fury; on 19 July 1870, France declared war on Prussia, walking directly into Bismarck's diplomatic trap as the apparent aggressor.

[2.1] The French military high command entered the campaign with supreme overconfidence, expecting their professional infantry armed with the modern *Chassepot* rifle to march triumphantly into Berlin. Instead, the Prussian military machine struck with devastating speed. General Helmuth von Moltke mobilized 380,000 troops across six dedicated rail lines within eleven days. The Prussian artillery—breech-loading cast-steel Krupp cannon—outranged and obliterated French muzzle-loading bronze artillery. On 1 September 1870 at the **Battle of Sedan**, Prussian forces surrounded the French army, capturing 104,000 soldiers and Emperor Napoleon III himself, instantly collapsing the French Second Empire.

[2.2] Rather than submitting, a newly proclaimed French Third Republic vowed to fight on. By late September 1870, Prussian armies had completely surrounded Paris. For over four agonizing months, two million Parisian citizens endured a freezing winter, subjected to artillery bombardment and starvation. Parisians were reduced to butchering horses, eating domestic pets, and slaughtering the elephants of the Jardin des Plantes zoo. In January 1871, exhausted and facing epidemic disease, Paris capitulated. Bismarck had broken the military might of France.

[3.1] The Treaty of Frankfurt, signed in May 1871, exacted a severe retribution upon France. Germany annexed 14,000 square kilometers of territory encompassing **Alsace and northern Lorraine** (Source B), seizing 1.5 million French citizens and 80% of France's iron ore reserves. German military engineers fortified the fortress cities of Metz and Strasbourg, transforming the region into an impenetrable military glacis protecting the Rhineland. In addition, an army of occupation remained on French soil until an astronomical indemnity of five billion gold francs was paid in full.

[3.2] In France, the territorial amputations produced an intense, institutionalized national trauma known as *la revanche* (revenge). In public classrooms across the Third Republic, educational paintings such as Albert Bettannier's *La Tache Noire* (Source A) portrayed solemn schoolmasters pointing to maps where Alsace-Lorraine was shaded in mourning black. Generations of French schoolchildren were raised on the sacred duty to reclaim their stolen brothers, epitomized by politician Léon Gambetta's famous maxim: "*Think of it always; speak of it never.*"

[4.1] Military historians and diplomatic scholars debate whether Bismarck's decision to annex Alsace-Lorraine was his greatest strategic miscalculation. Bismarck himself initially cautioned against annexing Lorraine with its French-speaking population, but was overruled by Field Marshal Moltke and the Prussian General Staff, who insisted on the fortress of Metz for defensive military security. Historian Gordon Craig argues that by prioritizing immediate military boundaries over long-term diplomatic reconciliation, Germany made a permanent enemy of France, foreclosing any possibility of a lasting European peace.

[4.2] The consequence of 1871 was the complete polarization of continental statecraft. To safeguard Germany against French retribution, Bismarck was compelled to construct an increasingly baroque network of defensive alliances, while France remained ever vigilant for an ally—eventually finding one in Tsarist Russia—to break its diplomatic isolation. The blood spilt at Sedan and the mourning maps in French classrooms ensured that when the crisis of 1914 erupted, French soldiers would march east not merely for treaty obligations, but to avenge 1870.

Q1. Explain how the Franco-Prussian War and the annexation of Alsace-Lorraine created a lasting legacy of hatred between France and Germany.

L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Contrast Bismarck's continental diplomacy with Kaiser Wilhelm II's "Weltpolitik".
- ☐ Analyze how the First Moroccan Crisis (1905) consolidated the Anglo-French Entente Cordiale.
- ☐ Evaluate the impact of the Agadir Crisis (1911) and the dispatch of the SMS Panther.

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:

Weltpolitik | Platz an der Sonne | Entente Cordiale | Gunboat Diplomacy | Einkreisung

Power, Governance & Warfare

Economy, Trade & Society

Source S1 : The Partition of Africa by 1914



Source

Geopolitical map showing the division of the African continent among European colonial empires following the 1884–85 Berlin Conference.

Source S2 : Gunboat Diplomacy: The SMS Panther at Agadir (1911)



Source

Archival photograph of the German Imperial Navy gunboat SMS Panther, dispatched by the Kaiser to the Moroccan port of Agadir on 1 July 1911.

[1.1] Throughout his tenure as Chancellor, Otto von Bismarck fiercely opposed acquiring overseas colonies, famously declaring: "My map of Africa lies in Europe. Here is Russia, and here is France, and we are in the middle; that is my map of Africa." Bismarck recognized that overseas adventures would inevitably provoke friction with Great Britain, whose global empire and naval supremacy guarded the world's maritime trade routes. To regulate imperial claims and prevent European warfare, Bismarck hosted the 1884–85 **Berlin Conference**, where European powers partitioned the African continent into colonial spheres without a single African leader present.

[1.2] However, when the ambitious and bellicose young Kaiser Wilhelm II ascended the throne in 1888, he chafed under Bismarck's cautious diplomacy. In 1890, Wilhelm forced Bismarck to resign and proclaimed a new, aggressive foreign policy: **Weltpolitik** (World Policy). Wilhelm declared that Germany's explosive industrial growth entitled the Reich to a "*Platz an der Sonne*" (a place in the sun)—a global colonial empire matching that of Britain and France. For Wilhelm, colonies were not merely economic assets, but the ultimate symbol of Great Power status.

[2.1] By the turn of the twentieth century, the vast majority of fertile African territory had been seized by Britain and France (Source A). Germany was left with arid, unprofitable colonies in Southwest Africa, Cameroon, and German East Africa. Feeling cheated, the Kaiser sought to exploit weak points in European colonial agreements. In 1904, Britain and France signed the **Entente Cordiale**, a diplomatic agreement resolving long-standing imperial disputes: France recognized British control of Egypt, while

Britain accepted French dominance over the independent Sultanate of Morocco.

[2.2] Determined to shatter this newfound Anglo-French friendship, Kaiser Wilhelm landed at the Moroccan port of Tangier in March 1905 riding a white charger. He publicly proclaimed his support for the Sultan's complete sovereignty and demanded an international conference to review Morocco's status. The gamble backfired catastrophically. At the 1906 **Algeciras Conference**, Britain, Russia, Italy, and the United States backed France; only Austria-Hungary supported Germany. Instead of driving a wedge between London and Paris, German posturing solidified the Entente Cordiale into a robust diplomatic partnership and initiated secret Anglo-French military staff talks.

[3.1] Five years later, imperial rivalry flared into open confrontation during the **Second Moroccan Crisis (1911)**. When Moroccan tribes rebelled against the Sultan, France dispatched troops to occupy the capital, Fez. Accusing France of violating the Algeciras agreements, the German government dispatched the imperial gunboat *SMS Panther* (Source B) to the Atlantic port of Agadir. This heavy-handed demonstration of "gunboat diplomacy" was intended to intimidate France into ceding the entire French Congo to Germany in exchange for accepting French control of Morocco.

[3.2] The arrival of a German warship on the Atlantic coast of Africa provoked panic and fury in London. British military strategists feared Germany intended to construct a fortified naval base at Agadir, threatening vital British sea routes to India and South Africa. Chancellor of the Exchequer David Lloyd George delivered the famous **Mansion House Speech**, warning that Britain would not tolerate German intimidation: *"If a situation were to be forced upon us in which peace could only be preserved by the surrender of the great and beneficent position Britain has won... then I say emphatically that peace at that price would be a humiliation intolerable for a great country like ours to endure."* Backed by British resolve, France held firm; Germany was forced to back down and accept a sliver of swampy Congolese land.

[4.1] Historiographers have long debated the role of colonial expansion in causing the Great War. Marxist-Leninist historians argued that imperialism was the primary driver of the conflict, asserting that capitalist monopolies inevitably competed for raw materials and colonial markets until war was inevitable. Conversely, modern historians such as Margaret MacMillan argue that imperial crises actually acted as safety valves for decades, allowing Great Powers to compete in distant territories without directly clashing in Europe.

[4.2] However, Kaiser Wilhelm's clumsy pursuit of *Weltpolitik* transformed colonial squabbles into existential European showdowns. The Moroccan Crises achieved the exact opposite of German strategic intentions: they drove Britain out of "Splendid Isolation," cemented the Anglo-French Entente, spurred joint military planning, and deepened Germany's paranoid fear of encirclement (*Einkreisung*). By 1911, German military leaders concluded that diplomacy was bankrupt and that only a European war could break their diplomatic isolation.

Q1. Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's policy of Weltpolitik and the Moroccan Crises drove Britain and France into a united diplomatic alliance against Germany.

L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the principles of the British Two-Power Standard and Tirpitz's "Risk Theory".
- ☐ Analyze the revolutionary technology of HMS Dreadnought and Admiral Jackie Fisher's reforms.
- ☐ Evaluate how public hysteria and popular slogans ("We want eight and we won't wait!") drove the naval arms race.

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:

Two-Power Standard | Dreadnought | Risk Theory | Kiel Canal | Splendid Isolation

Challenge: Write ONE statement containing a deliberate historical misconception using **Two-Power Standard** or **Dreadnought**. Identify and correct the error:

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:

Source S1 : Admiral Sir John Fisher: Confidential Admiralty Memorandum (1906)

"My principles are: Speed is armor. Hit first, hit hard, and keep on hitting... The Dreadnought has rendered all existing battleships obsolete. If Germany builds one, we must build two. The Empire floats upon the Royal Navy; if the navy is defeated, we are starved into surrender in three weeks. We cannot afford sentiment or hesitation."

Extract from Admiral Sir John Fisher's secret memorandum to the Board of Admiralty outlining the strategic philosophy of HMS Dreadnought.

Source S2 : Puck Magazine: "The Armaments Race" (1909)



Source

Contemporary American political cartoon showing John Bull (Britain) and Kaiser Wilhelm II pouring gold sovereigns and marks into an insatiable furnace of battleship construction.

[1.1] Throughout the nineteenth century, Great Britain's national survival and imperial prosperity rested upon undisputed command of the oceans. As an island nation dependent on maritime commerce for its raw materials and sixty percent of its food supply, defeat at sea meant catastrophic national starvation within weeks. Under the **Naval Defence Act of 1889**, Britain codified the **Two-Power Standard**: the Royal Navy was legally mandated to maintain a battle fleet at least equal to the combined strength of the world's next two largest navies (then France and Russia). This massive armada guarded four hundred million colonial subjects and safeguarded Britain in "Splendid Isolation."

[1.2] However, Kaiser Wilhelm II—an avid grandson of Queen Victoria who grew up fascinated by British naval reviews at Spithead—was determined that Germany must possess a fleet matching its industrial might. In 1897, he appointed the visionary and fanatical **Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz** as State Secretary of the Imperial Navy. Tirpitz formulated the celebrated **Risk Theory** (*Risikotheorie*): Germany did not need to

out-build the entire Royal Navy; it merely needed to construct a fleet so formidable in the North Sea that Britain could not risk attacking it without suffering such catastrophic losses that its global naval empire would collapse. Between 1898 and 1900, Tirpitz rammed successive Navy Laws through the Reichstag to fund a massive High Seas Fleet.

[2.1] The rapid growth of German dockyards on the North Sea struck terror into the British Admiralty. In October 1904, a brilliant, eccentric reformer named **Admiral Sir John "Jackie" Fisher** was appointed First Sea Lord. Fisher recognized that incremental improvements were futile; Britain required a technological leap that would paralyze all rivals. In 1906, Fisher unveiled **HMS Dreadnought**, a revolutionary leviathan that transformed naval warfare overnight. Armed with ten 12-inch guns (compared to the four carried by traditional pre-dreadnoughts) and powered by revolutionary Parsons steam turbines capable of twenty-one knots, *Dreadnought* was faster and boasted two and a half times the broadside firepower of any ship afloat.

[2.2] Yet Fisher's masterpiece was a dangerous double-edged sword. By rendering every existing battleship instantly obsolete, *Dreadnought* wiped out Britain's enormous numerical advantage in pre-dreadnought battleships. The naval race was effectively reset to zero: Germany could now compete on equal terms by building its own dreadnoughts. Tirpitz immediately widened the Kiel Canal at immense expense and laid down the *Nassau*-class dreadnoughts. The arms race became an industrial sprint.

[3.1] In his confidential 1906 policy memorandum (Source A), Fisher outlined his ruthless doctrine of deterrent power: *"Speed is armor. Hit first, hit hard, and keep on hitting... If Germany builds one, we must build two."* Fisher even privately proposed to King Edward VII that the Royal Navy should "Copenhagen" the German fleet—launching a surprise pre-emptive strike to annihilate the German ships in their harbors before they could be completed. While British politicians rejected unprovoked war, the Admiralty escalated construction to astronomical levels.

[3.2] By 1909, false rumors that Germany was secretly accelerating construction provoked widespread public panic in Great Britain. Supported by the Conservative opposition and the powerful Navy League, British citizens marched in the streets chanting the famous jingle: **"We want eight and we won't wait!"**—demanding eight new dreadnoughts in a single budgetary year. Satirical publications (Source B) depicted Britain and Germany as crazed gamblers pouring their national wealth into steel furnaces, crippling domestic social reform programs to fund floating dreadnought fortresses.

[4.1] By 1912, Britain had decisively won the naval construction race. Thanks to its unmatched shipbuilding capacity and the financial resources of the British Empire, the Royal Navy possessed twenty-nine dreadnoughts and super-dreadnoughts compared to Germany's seventeen. Recognizing that he could not out-build Britain and facing an escalating land army expansion in Russia and France, the Kaiser abandoned the naval race in 1912 to redirect imperial funds back into the German army.

[4.2] Nevertheless, historians agree that Tirpitz's naval challenge was the single greatest diplomatic blunder in modern German history. As historian Paul Kennedy demonstrates, the naval race achieved zero military advantage for Germany—the High Seas Fleet spent almost the entire First World War bottled up in port—while irrevocably destroying Anglo-German relations. Britain, which had remained friendly or detached from continental disputes for a century, was permanently driven into an anti-German diplomatic alliance with France and Russia. By building a fleet in the North Sea, Germany had aimed a dagger straight at the heart of the British Empire.

Q1. Explain why the Anglo-German naval arms race destroyed diplomatic trust between Great Britain and Germany between 1898 and 1914.

L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain the formation of the Dual Alliance (1879) and Triple Alliance (1882).
- ☐ Analyze why the lapse of the Reinsurance Treaty led to the Franco-Russian Alliance (1894).
- ☐ Evaluate the mechanics of the Schlieffen Plan and the rigidity of military mobilization.

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: Circle *ONE* term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?

Triple Alliance | Triple Entente | Schlieffen Plan | Reinsurance Treaty | Mobilization

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Source S1 : The Armed Camps: Central Powers vs Triple Entente (1914)



Source

Geopolitical map showing the division of Europe into two opposing armed alliances: the Central Powers surrounded by the Triple Entente.

Source S2 : The Schlieffen Plan: The German Great General Staff Offensive



Source

Military operational map illustrating Count Alfred von Schlieffen's 1905 strategy to rapidly defeat France through neutral Belgium before pivoting to face Russia.

[1.1] Following the unification of Germany in 1871, Chancellor Otto von Bismarck lived in terror of *la revanche*—the prospect of France forging a military alliance with another Great Power to wage a two-front war of retribution. To prevent this encirclement, Bismarck spun an intricate diplomatic web. In 1879, Germany concluded the **Dual Alliance** with Austria-Hungary, pledging mutual defence against any Russian attack. In 1882, this pact expanded into the **Triple Alliance** when Italy joined, motivated by colonial grievances against France. Crucially, Bismarck maintained a secret **Reinsurance Treaty** with Tsarist Russia in 1887, ensuring that as long as Bismarck was Chancellor, St. Petersburg and Berlin remained tied together, leaving France completely isolated.

[1.2] However, when Kaiser Wilhelm II dismissed Bismarck in 1890, the young emperor recklessly dismantled this delicate diplomatic machinery. Viewing the secret treaty with Russia as overly complicated and conflicting with Germany's Austrian alliance, Wilhelm allowed the Reinsurance Treaty to lapse. St. Petersburg felt betrayed and vulnerable. Despite their profound ideological differences—revolutionary republican France and reactionary, autocratic Tsarist Russia—the two isolated powers recognized their shared peril. In 1894, they concluded the formal **Franco-Russian Military Alliance**. Bismarck's ultimate nightmare had become reality: Germany was encircled by hostile powers on its eastern and western frontiers.

[2.1] Alarmed by Germany's explosive industrial expansion and Tirpitz's aggressive naval construction in the North Sea, Great Britain abandoned its historic policy of "Splendid Isolation." In 1904, Britain settled century-old imperial disputes with France by signing the **Entente Cordiale**. Three years later, encouraged by France, Britain concluded the **Anglo-Russian Convention of 1907**, resolving long-standing imperial rivalries in Persia, Afghanistan, and Tibet. Together, Britain, France, and Russia formed the **Triple Entente** (Source A). Although the Entente was technically a diplomatic alignment rather than a binding military alliance, German planners interpreted it as a deliberate ring of hostile encirclement (*Einkreisung*) designed to strangle Germany's legitimate Great Power ambitions.

[2.2] The rigidity of the alliance blocs was demonstrated during the **Bosnian Crisis of 1908**. Austria-Hungary abruptly annexed the Ottoman provinces of Bosnia and Herzegovina, which it had administered since 1878. The annexation outraged neighboring Serbia, which dreamed of uniting all South Slavs into a Greater Serbia, and provoked fury in Russia, the self-proclaimed protector of all Slavic peoples. When Germany issued a humiliating ultimatum to St. Petersburg—declaring it would mobilize alongside Austria if Russia intervened—Tsar Nicholas II, still recovering from military defeat against Japan in 1905, was forced to back down. The humiliation was intolerable: Russia vowed that it would never again retreat in the Balkans, accelerating a colossal army modernization program scheduled for completion in 1917.

[3.1] Forensic military maps (Source A) expose the terrifying geopolitical trap confronting Imperial Germany. Sandwiched between the massive, modernizing peasant army of the Russian Empire (1.4 million men under arms) and the heavily fortified frontier of France (800,000 men), German military planners concluded that time was running out. German Chief of the General Staff, Helmuth von Moltke (the Younger), warned the Kaiser in 1912: *"War is inevitable, and the sooner the better."* German planners feared that once Russian railways across Poland were completed in 1917, the Tsarist steamroller could mobilize in days, rendering Germany completely indefensible.

[3.2] To escape this strategic cage, the German General Staff staked its survival upon the **Schlieffen Plan** (Source B), drafted in 1905 by Count Alfred von Schlieffen. Assuming that Russia's vast distances and primitive infrastructure would require six weeks (forty-two days) to mobilize its forces, Germany would deploy ninety percent of its army in a massive right-wing sweep through neutral Belgium and northern France. Encircling Paris from the west within thirty-nine days, the German army would crush French resistance before wheeling east via specialized railways to confront the slowly mobilizing Russian giant. Crucially, the Schlieffen Plan was entirely dependent on rigid, unalterable railway timetables: once the mobilization button was pushed, diplomacy had to stop.

[4.1] For decades following the war, revisionist historians such as Sidney Fay argued that the alliance system was the primary structural cause of the catastrophe. In this view, secret, entangling alliances acted as an automatic doomsday machine: when Austria quarreled with Serbia, the interlocking treaty commitments inexorably dragged Germany, Russia, France, and Britain into a world war that none of their leaders genuinely wanted or anticipated.

[4.2] Modern historiography, led by Christopher Clark (*The Sleepwalkers*) and Margaret MacMillan, offers a far more nuanced verdict. Alliances had successfully preserved European peace for over thirty years; they were intended as defensive deterrents, not offensive mandates. What caused the war in 1914 was not the treaties themselves, but the militarization of European statecraft and the fatal illusion among military staffs that striking first was the only guarantee of survival. By subordinating diplomatic negotiations to rigid military railway timetables, European leaders transformed defensive pacts into inescapable traps.

Q1. Explain how the division of Europe into the Triple Alliance and Triple Entente transformed minor regional disputes into a continental crisis.

L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Explain why Archduke Franz Ferdinand was targeted by the Black Hand in Sarajevo on 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Analyze the fateful coincidences and wrong turns during the assassination on 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Evaluate the July Crisis, the German "Blank Cheque", and the domino effect of European mobilization.

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):

Blank Cheque | Black Hand | Ultimatum | Pan-Slavism | July Crisis

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

Source S1 : Sarajevo Police Map: Appel Quay & Franz Josef Street (28 June 1914)



Source

Police forensic sketch showing the fatal wrong turn taken by Archduke Franz Ferdinand's motorcade onto Franz Josef Street, where the car stalled in front of Gavrilo Princip.

Source S2 : The Secret Constitution & Blood Oath of the "Black Hand" (1911)

"Article 1: This organization is created for the purpose of realizing the national ideal: the union of all Serbs... Article 2: This organization prefers terrorist action to ideological propaganda. It must therefore remain absolutely secret from the non-initiated.

The Sacred Oath: 'I, in joining the organization Union or Death, do swear by the sun that warms me, by the earth that nourishes me, before God, by the blood of my ancestors, on my honor and life, that from this moment until my death I will faithfully serve this organization, and that I will be prepared to endure all sacrifices for it. If I break this oath, let God and my comrades judge me.'"

Extracts from the founding constitution and sacred initiation oath of the clandestine Serbian terrorist society "Union or Death" (The Black Hand), Belgrade, 1911.

[1.1] In the early twentieth century, southeastern Europe was universally recognized as the **Powder Keg of Europe**. As the Ottoman Empire ("The Sick Man of Europe") steadily retreated from the Balkan peninsula, rival nationalist passions and Great Power ambitions filled the vacuum. The Kingdom of Serbia, backed by Tsarist Russia under the banner of Pan-Slavism, dreamed of liberating all South Slavs from foreign imperial rule to create a united "Yugoslavia". Standing directly in the path of this ambition was the multinational Austro-Hungarian Empire, which ruled over millions of discontented Croats, Slovenes, and Bosnians. Vienna viewed Serbian nationalism as an existential cancer that threatened to tear its fragile empire apart.

[1.2] In 1911, radical Serbian officers founded a clandestine terrorist society named *Ujedinjenje ili Smrt* ("Union or Death"), popularly known as the **Black Hand** (Source B). Commanded by the head of Serbian Military Intelligence, Colonel Dragutin Dimitrijević (code-named "Apis"), the organization operated secret training camps, smuggled weapons, and coordinated assassinations. When it was announced that **Archduke Franz Ferdinand**, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, would inspect military maneuvers in Sarajevo, Bosnia, in June 1914, Apis recognized a supreme target. The Archduke was a moderate reformer who advocated granting Slavs equal political status inside the Austro-Hungarian Empire—a reform Serbian extremists terrified would satisfy Bosnian Slavs and destroy dreams of a Greater Serbia.

[2.1] On Sunday, 28 June 1914—the sacred anniversary of the 1389 Battle of Kosovo, a day of intense Serbian national mourning and defiance—Archduke Franz Ferdinand and his pregnant wife Sophie arrived in Sarajevo. Security was extraordinarily lax: the local governor had refused to deploy regular troops along the route, leaving the royal couple in an open-topped Graf & Stift cabriolet protected by only a handful of police officers. Six teenage Bosnian Serb conspirators, armed by the Black Hand with Belgian semi-automatic pistols, hand bombs, and cyanide capsules, stationed themselves along the Appel Quay boulevard bordering the Miljacka River.

[2.2] The initial assassination attempt was a fiasco. Conspirator Nedeljko Čabrinović threw a bomb that bounced off the folded roof of the royal car and exploded beneath the vehicle behind, wounding twenty bystanders. The Archduke drove on to the Town Hall, furiously rebuking the mayor: *"So this is how you welcome your guests—with bombs!"* After the reception, the Archduke decided to visit the wounded officers in the hospital. However, his drivers were never informed of the altered route. Turning off Appel Quay onto Franz Josef Street (Source A), the lead car realized its mistake and stopped. The royal driver applied the brakes and attempted to reverse, stalling the open cabriolet directly outside Schiller's Delicatessen—barely five feet from nineteen-year-old **Gavrilo Princip**. Princip drew his pistol and fired two shots at point-blank range, fatally severing the Archduke's jugular vein and striking Sophie in the abdomen.

[3.1] While the world mourned a royal tragedy, hawks in Vienna saw a golden opportunity to crush Serbia once and for all. However, terrified that attacking Serbia would provoke Tsarist Russia into war, Austria sought guarantees from Berlin. On 5 July 1914, Kaiser Wilhelm II issued the fateful **Blank Cheque**: Germany promised unconditional military backing to Austria-Hungary, urging Vienna to act swiftly while world sympathy remained on its side. Emboldened by this ironclad German pledge, Austria delivered a deliberately unacceptable ten-point **Ultimatum** to Serbia on 23 July, giving Belgrade just forty-eight hours to accept. Despite Serbia accepting eight of the ten demands, Austria severed diplomatic relations and declared war on Serbia on 28 July 1914, bombarding Belgrade across the Danube.

[3.2] The declaration triggered the fatal domino effect of European mobilization timetables. Russia, determined never to repeat the humiliation of the 1908 Bosnian Crisis, ordered general mobilization on 30 July to defend Serbia. In Berlin, German military planners panicked: under the Schlieffen Plan, every hour Russia mobilized without German action brought disaster. Germany issued an ultimatum demanding Russia demobilize within twelve hours; when St. Petersburg refused, Germany declared war on Russia on 1 August and on France on 3 August. When German troops stormed into neutral Belgium on 4 August to enact the Schlieffen Plan, Great Britain honored the 1839 Treaty of London and declared war on Germany. Within thirty days of madness, the assassination of one man had plunged seventy million soldiers into world war.

[4.1] For over a century, the question of war guilt has stood at the absolute center of modern historical debate. In 1919, the victorious Allies forced Germany to sign Article 231 of the Treaty of Versailles—the "War Guilt Clause"—declaring that Germany alone was responsible for unleashing the war. In the 1960s, prominent German historian **Fritz Fischer** created an academic earthquake by arguing, using newly opened imperial archives, that German imperial leaders deliberately exploited the Sarajevo crisis to engineer a pre-emptive European war to achieve continental hegemony and break out of British encirclement.

[4.2] Conversely, modern historiography has challenged the Fischer thesis. In his landmark 2012 study *The Sleepwalkers*, historian **Christopher Clark** demonstrates that no single Great Power planned a general war. Instead, European leaders were "sleepwalkers, watchful but unseeing, blind to the reality of the horror they were about to bring into the world." The catastrophe of August 1914 was not the product of a single aggressive conspiracy, but the tragic culmination of interlocking alliance commitments, reckless brinkmanship, military paranoia, and the fatal failure of diplomatic imagination.

Q1. Explain why the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in Sarajevo led directly to the outbreak of the First World War in August 1914.

Generated: 2026-09-22 09:49:09 UTC | Unit: great_war